Communication & the Social Context of Language

Culture, language and communication: verbal and non-verbal communication; social context of language use

3 PYQs 2017 · 2020 · 2021
45 marks · the 2020 inequality stem is a 20-marker · none
2022–2026 · Mains Value **Medium**

THE ANSWER SPINE ① Channels → ② Universal and cultural → ③ Context → ④ Variation → ⑤ Inequality

① COMMUNICATION — WORDS DO SOCIAL WORK

frames every answer

Definition: transmission of meaning through shared symbols and signals, verbal and non-verbal, within a cultural context.

Verbal carries content; **non-verbal** carries relationship, emotion, status — and is believed when the two conflict.

HOOK *"Nice weather today!" tells no one anything — yet silence would insult. Malinowski 1923:* **phatic communion** .

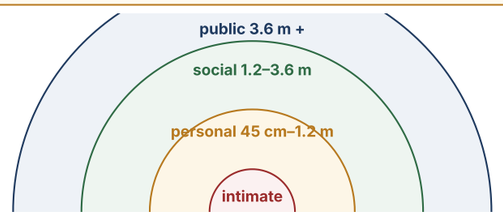
Malinowski 1923 — context of situation; language as a "mode of action".
Other codes: Silbo Gomero (whistled Spanish, UNESCO 2009) · talking drums · sign languages (ISLRTC 2015).

② NON-VERBAL CHANNELS

2017 · 10M note

Kinesics — gesture, face (Birdwhistell 1952)
Proxemics — space (Hall 1959, 1966)
Paralanguage — tone, pause (Trager 1958)
Haptics — touch: feet, hands
Chronemics — mono- / polychronic
Oculesics — gaze, avoidance
Artefacts — sindoor, thread, tattoos
Silence — Western Apache (Basso 1970)

HOOK *Hall's diplomat backs away as his Latin American colleague steps closer — until he hits the wall. Each thinks the other rude; it was culture.*



Hall 1966

Ekman & Friesen 1969 — five functions: emblems · illustrators · affect displays · regulators · adaptors.

India — non-verbal hierarchy: touching elders' feet (*charan sparsh*) · *namaste* vs handshake · *ghunghat* and lowered gaze before in-laws · silence before elders · the head-tilt "yes" · historical Kerala **distance pollution** — caste fixed physical space itself.

Basis	Verbal	Non-verbal
Carries	content	emotion, relation, status
Structure	discrete, productive	often graded
Control	deliberate	often unconscious
Universal?	capacity only	a few expressions

★ HERO — COMMUNICATION IN CONTEXT

draw for 2017 · 2021

VERBAL — content
speech · writing · sign
speech acts — "I do"
register · dialect · sociolect
honorifics — aap / tum / tu
code-switching · diglossia
phatic talk
whistle · drum codes
what is said

THE MESSAGE
words + body + voice + space + time
conflict? trust the non-verbal

NON-VERBAL — relation
kinesics · face
proxemics · space
paralanguage · voice
haptics · touch
chronemics · time
gaze · artefacts
silence
how it is meant

THE FRAME — Hymes's SPEAKING (1972) · communicative competence

S	P	E	A	K	I	N	G
setting	participants	ends	act sequence	key	instruments	norms	genre

③ UNIVERSAL OR CULTURAL? · LANGUAGE IN CONTEXT

2021 · 15M

HOOK *Ekman showed American faces to the Fore of New Guinea: they matched joy, sadness, anger and disgust — but mixed up fear and surprise.*

Universal core: Darwin 1872; Ekman & Friesen 1971 — six basic expressions. **Cultural rest:** display rules (Japanese students masked disgust); emblems differ — Indian head-tilt = yes; Bulgarian nod = no. **Do not quote 7–38–55 (Mehrabian 1967) as a law.**

HOOK *"I do" doesn't describe a marriage — it makes one. Austin 1962: performatives.*

Austin 1962 speech acts · **Hymes 1962/72** ethnography of speaking; **communicative competence** vs Chomsky · **Gumperz** speech community · **register** · **code-switching** — Blom & Gumperz 1972, Hemnesberget; Hinglish · **diglossia** — Ferguson 1959; literary vs spoken Tamil · **pidgin/creole** — Nagamese · **honorifics** — Javanese speech levels (Geertz 1960).

Branches (2021): descriptive · historical (Jones 1786; Swadesh) · ethnolinguistics (Whorf, Conklin) · sociolinguistics (Labov, Ferguson) · ethnography of communication (Hymes, Gumperz). Duranti 2003: documentation → ethnography of communication → language as social action.

Basis	Code-switching	Diglossia
Level	individual, in one conversation	societal, by domain
Varieties	any two languages/dialects	high + low of one language
Choice	strategic, fluid	fixed by function
Case	Hinglish; Hemnesberget	Tamil; Arabic

Line: knowing a language is knowing its grammar; **using it is knowing its society**.

④ VARIATION — SPEECH MAPS SOCIETY

2020 · 20M

HOOK *Labov, 1962: "Where are the women's shoes?" — "Fourth floor." The r in "fourth floor" fell from Saks (~6 in 10) to Macy's (~5) to S. Klein (~2).*

- **Class** — Labov 1966, New York; style-shifting toward prestige forms.
- **Caste** — Gumperz 1958, Khalapur (UP); Bright & Ramanujan 1964, Brahmin/non-Brahmin dialects.
- **Gender** — Lakoff 1975; Tannen 1990; husband's-name taboos.
- **Region, ethnicity** — standard Hindi over Bhojpuri; AAVE.

HOOK *Gumperz in Khalapur: one "village dialect", many caste versions — sharpest between touchable and untouchable castes.*

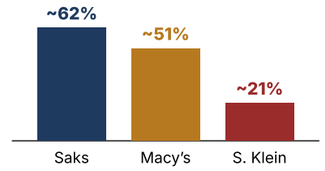
⑤ INEQUALITY — THE MECHANISM

2020 · the one to over-prepare

Variation — groups speak differently
Evaluation — language ideology: one variety "correct" (Irvine & Gal)
Access — school rewards the elaborated code (Bernstein 1971); linguistic capital (Bourdieu 1991); gatekeeping (Gumperz 1982)
Reproduction — hierarchy passes on

Counter-case — Labov 1969, "The Logic of Nonstandard English": difference, not deficit — stigmatised varieties are fully rule-governed.

India: English as capital · tribal children taught only in a standard they do not speak · Odisha's tribal multilingual education · **Article 350A** · NEP 2020 · only 22 scheduled languages · Sanskritisation of speech (Srinivas).



Bernstein vs Labov
restricted / elaborated codes; school rewards one (1971)
nonstandard is fully logical: difference, not deficit (1969)

Traps: code-switching (individual, fluid) ≠ diglossia (societal, fixed) · Bernstein was *read* as deficit · Ekman's universals ≠ gestures.

THE VERDICT TO WRITE Communication runs on several channels at once: **words carry content; body, voice, space and time carry the relationship**. A few facial expressions are universal; most gestures, distances and touch rules are learnt. Knowing a language is knowing its grammar; **using it is knowing its society** (Hymes). Because groups speak differently and one variety is made the price of entry to school, work and law, **variation becomes inequality** — answered by Labov's "difference, not deficit" and by mother-tongue education.